

that government benefited society, Daoists defended private life and wanted rulers to leave people alone. The best way to live was through *wu wei* (action that avoided effort), and the perfect ruler was one who made no laws, imposed no restrictions on his subjects, and whose actions went unnoticed.

As a philosophy of individualism and inaction, Daoism's practical applications for government were limited. Yet it had a lasting influence on later philosophy and religion, especially Chinese Buddhism.

Legalism

The most successful philosophy during the Warring States period was *Fajia* ("standards"), known in the West as Legalism. Legalists believed that people were essentially self-interested, lazy, and ignorant. The way to create social order and a strong state was to deter crime with strict laws and punishments. Even light offenses should be punished harshly.

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Do not value goods
that are hard to come by,
and the people
will not steal.”

Laozi
Dao de Jing, 4th century BCE

In the 4th century BCE, Legalism was adopted by Shang Yang, chief minister of the western state of Qin. *The Book of Lord Shang*, a compilation of writings by Shang and his followers, attacks the beliefs of Confucianism, saying that reverence for the past and traditions encourage people to criticize their present rulers. Even humaneness and virtue undermine the law.

The Book of Lord Shang argues that wicked people should be in positions of power for two reasons: people's loyalty should be to the laws themselves, not to the people who enforce the laws; and wicked people are likely to report offenses because they like to spy on others.

The penalties imposed by Shang Yang were humiliating and painful. They included facial tattooing, mutilation, and public execution in various ways, such as being boiled, quartered, or buried alive. Punishment was also collective, extending to the whole family or clan of an offender. Failure to report a crime was treated as harshly as committing one.

Using Legalism, Shang Yang created a strong authoritarian state and a powerful army of peasants who were conscripted as soldiers. He destroyed the feudal power of the nobility, who were now subject to the same laws as everyone else. When a new ruler whom Shang Yang had previously humiliated

In Qin dynasty China, the philosophy of Legalism was followed strictly, with the law-making emperor at the top of the social pyramid and the slaves at the bottom.

